
Publishing Reports from Markdown

A recommendation for Life Itself's report pipeline, and what it costs to adopt

IN BRIEF

Life Itself should typeset reports with Typst, driven from Markdown, using one of three specified template styles chosen per document. The toolchain is settled; what was missing was a design specification, and that is now written. The remaining work is content-side, not engineering: choosing which sentences become pull quotes and which numbers become key figures.

A. The problem

Markdown in, PDF out, and it has to look considered. A Google Docs export is not a typeset document. It is ragged, unhyphenated, has one piece of page furniture (a centred folio) and treats an image as something dropped between two paragraphs. Reports produced that way read as internal memos regardless of how good the argument is.

The gap is not a font gap. Comparing three well-regarded published reports page by page¹ shows they disagree about almost every choice a template makes — one justifies and two do not, one uses three type families and one uses one — and agree completely about discipline.

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reports read page by page, at 46, 87 and 96 pages

The professional look is the consistency, not the choices.

That is good news for a template: it means there is no single correct design to discover, only a coherent one to specify and then obey.

B. The recommendation

¹Civilization Research Institute, *Reality Check* (2025); The Mindfulness Initiative, *Reconnection* Planetary Civics Inquiry, *A New Framework for Planetary Futures* (2024). Full readings in docs/report-design-principles.md.

KEY MESSAGE 1

Adopt Typst with three specified styles, not one

Typst compiles Markdown to PDF in about a second, vendors its own fonts, and expresses page furniture directly. Three template styles — Review, Essay and Brief — cover the document types Life Itself actually publishes. Each is written as a Markdown specification first and implemented second, so the design is reviewable by someone who does not read code.

Why three and not one

An earlier version of this work aimed at a single strong template.

That was the right instinct and the wrong number. The three document types have incompatible requirements:

- an evidence review needs a margin rail so a source credit never interrupts a sentence;
- a long-form essay needs the fewest possible devices and the most air;
- a brief needs boxes, footnotes and a short measure, because it will be read in fragments and acted on.

A single template that served all three would be a template that had not decided what it was. Choosing per document takes about ten seconds and the choice is written down.

Every measurement here is specified in docs/styles/brief.md §1 and implemented in typst/lib/styles/brief.typ.

HOW TO CHOOSE

Three questions

Is the reader expected to **check** it — data, citations, sources? Use **Review**.

Is the reader expected to be **carried through** an argument? Use **Essay**.

Is the reader expected to **act** on it, and probably to read only some of it? Use **Brief**.

What each style fixes

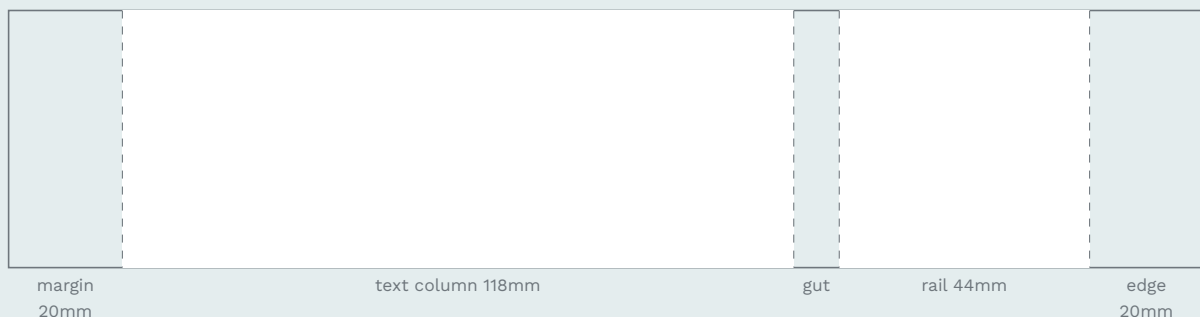


Figure 1. The Brief grid. The rail is on the right, after the text rather than before it: it summarises what has just been read instead of annotating what is being read. Boxes and figures may span the whole 170mm, which is this style's strongest visual event and should stay rare.

C. What it costs to adopt

Engineering: done

The pipeline exists. Markdown is cleaned by a small set of scripts, passed through Pandoc to Typst markup, and compiled against one of the three styles. Fonts are vendored under an open licence, so a build produces the same PDF on any machine.²

Editorial: the real remaining work

The devices that make the exemplar pages breathe — pull quotes, standfirsts, key figures, boxed key messages — all require someone to decide *which* sentence or number gets lifted. That is a content judgement, and no amount of template work substitutes for it.

Pick one or two interruption devices per style and use them systematically, not decoratively. The device is a voice change — different family, size, colour, or ground — not a different piece of content. Prose lifted verbatim into a pull quote still works.
— docs/report-design-principles.md, principle 3

~30 min

per chapter, to choose standfirsts and pull quotes

Budget roughly half an hour per chapter with an author. After that the template renders the devices for free, and the difference between a page that reads as a grey slab and one that reads as designed is made.

What is still open

- The copyright and licence line is placeholder text and needs a real decision.
- Print-on-demand trim size, bleed and binding gutter are not addressed; all three styles are specified for A4 screen and office print.
- Covers remain bespoke artwork rather than templated, which is probably correct but is not written down anywhere as a decision.

D. Recommendation

RECOMMENDATION

Ship the three styles; spend the next hour on editorial, not on code

The specifications in docs/styles/ are complete and implemented, and each has an example PDF built from real content so the claims in the specs are checkable rather than asserted. The highest-value next action is not another template pass — it is sitting down with an author and choosing the pull quotes.

²Left to itself Typst falls back silently to whatever the machine has installed — the same source produced Liberation Sans in one sandbox and a system serif on macOS. Vendoring is not optional.